

Chapter 111-1

Chen Mian.

This name had been frequently mentioned since last night, so Liang Shi naturally knew it.

However, she didn't know if the Chen Mian that Gu Xingyue was referring to was the same person Liang Wanwan had been talking about yesterday.

Liang Shi paused for a moment before answering, "I know one—she was my art studio classmate in middle school."

"Then let's talk when we meet." Gu Xingyue said and quickly hung up the phone.

Liang Shi drove to Gulang Pavilion.

This was a highly private tea house where many people came to discuss matters.

It was just past noon, and there weren't many people in the tea house.

As soon as she entered, she was surrounded by the lingering fragrance of tea, refreshing and pleasant. A server proactively came forward to ask, "Do you have a reservation?"

Liang Shi shook her head. "I don't know."

She called Gu Xingyue, but the other party didn't answer.

Liang Shi's heart was pounding with nervousness, somewhat afraid that it was Yang Jiani who had made Gu Xingyue call her.

But Yang Jiani had no motive to do such a thing. Even if she found out about Liang Shi's contact with Gu Xingyue, what could she do?

Even Zhou Yi'an's father couldn't cover the sky with one hand¹, so what could she possibly do?

Liang Shi was only worried that Gu Xingyue had fallen into danger.

Just as she was hesitating whether to call Gu Xingyue again, she received a text message:
【1007.】

Just four numbers. She thought for a moment and asked the server, "Do you have a private room 1007 here?"

"Yes, miss." The server said as she led her there.

Liang Shi stood at the door of room 1007, curled her fingers and knocked three times. The door opened from inside.

It was Gu Xingyue.

She was still wearing a light yellow long dress with a cardigan over it. Her hair was tied up with a blue scrunchie², and her makeup was fresh and elegant.

She looked gentle and serene.

This was her usual attire.

In the past, whenever Liang Shi saw Gu Xingyue dressed this way, she always felt that the temperament emanating from her bones matched this style of dress, making it appear particularly harmonious.

It also suited her face perfectly.

But today, Liang Shi had a strong feeling that Gu Xingyue shouldn't be like this.

She was gentle, yes, but there was a resilient toughness deep in her bones.

If the Qi Jiao in her memories was like hot spring water, then Gu Xingyue was flowing water.

Sometimes like a stream, sometimes like a waterfall.

But now Yang Jiani only gave her the opportunity to be a stream.

So she had suppressed her waterfall nature.

Yet once given the chance, the waterfall would surely cascade down with tremendous force.

Gu Xingyue was merely playing the role of Qi Jiao.

So this was probably the style of dress that Yang Jiani liked.

All of Gu Xingyue's emotions were hidden away. She sat kneeling on a cushion, and on the natural wood-colored table sat two cups of hot tea. The blue-green porcelain cups were pleasing to the eye.

But inexplicably, Liang Shi sensed a trace of tension.

Liang Shi sat across from Gu Xingyue and found her sitting there in a daze, her eyes staring at some unknown spot on the table, devoid of any sparkle.

Liang Shi didn't speak either, waiting for her to come back to herself, and instead picked up the teacup and took a small sip.

A few seconds later, Gu Xingyue's eyes moved as she came back to her senses. Upon seeing Liang Shi, she let out a light breath and, without any unnecessary words, went straight to the point. "This is Qi Jiao's complete diary."

Gu Xingyue handed over a notebook—it was a fairly new diary.

"As you've seen, all her diary entries were written in Morse code because she was afraid Yang Jiani would see them." When Gu Xingyue said this, she suddenly pressed her lips together, lowered her eyes to look at the teacup on the table, and as if somewhat nervous, picked up the cup and drank it all in one gulp.

A tea leaf still clung to the corner of her mouth.

After drinking, she took a piece of paper to wipe the water stains from her lips, then picked up the tea leaf and placed it on the table. Then she said in a deep voice, "I forgot to introduce myself to you."

Gu Xingyue looked at her, and in those eyes were indifference and fearlessness, different from before.

There was a feeling of having seen through life and death.

After not seeing her for a while, Gu Xingyue had acquired a bit more coldness.

"My name is Gu Xingyue." Gu Xingyue smiled slightly. "You should know by now—I grew up in Angel Orphanage, and my current name is Qi Jiao. I've been living under Qi Jiao's name for..."

She paused, then shook her head with a bitter smile. "I can't remember clearly anymore."

She had already lost any feeling about it.

Yesterday and today were no different; it was the same environment, the same feelings.

The same hardship to endure.

She really couldn't remember clearly anymore. Anyway, she must have been Qi Jiao for many, many years now. No one had called her Yueyue³ anymore.

No one had called out her name—Gu Xingyue!

The only name she was known by was Qi Jiao.

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1. "Cover the sky with one hand" (只手遮天) is a Chinese idiom meaning to monopolize power and deceive everyone, or to have absolute control over a situation. ⇐
 2. The original Chinese term "大腸圈" literally translates to "intestine ring," which is a colloquial term for a scrunchie—a fabric-covered elastic hair tie that has a gathered, ruched appearance. ⇐
 3. "Yueyue" (月月) is an affectionate nickname derived from the "月" (moon/month) character in Gu Xingyue's name. In Chinese, it's common to create nicknames by repeating a character from someone's name. ⇐

Chapter 111-2

Gu Xingyue looked at Liang Shi. "What did you want to find me for before? To sue Yang Jiani?"

Liang Shi shook her head. "The boundaries of domestic violence are too broad. Even suing her wouldn't be enough to put her in prison. But Qi Jiao has been dead for less than twenty years—we can still get justice for her."

At first, Liang Shi had wanted to confirm the authenticity of that memory. Later, she wanted to make Yang Jiani pay the price.

But she hadn't expected it to be tangled up in such a big matter.

Yang Jiani was too bold.

Or rather, she had already gone insane. This was absolutely not something a normal person could do.

Liang Shi even felt that even if they sued Yang Jiani, she might ultimately escape legal punishment by pleading mental illness.

Now that she knew, there was no reason to pretend to be deaf and mute.

Just based on what happened in childhood, Liang Shi felt she should get justice for Qi Jiao.

She couldn't just die for no reason like that, unable to even possess her own name.

She should be Qi Jiao—Qi Jiao who lived for herself.

Gu Xingyue looked at her. "But there's a problem now. If we want to get justice for Qi Jiao, I would have to come forward. I would have to say that I am Gu Xingyue, that the real Qi Jiao is dead. But no one knows how she died, and there's no evidence pointing to Yang Jiani as the culprit, because Yang Jiani is Qi Jiao's biological mother."

Unless there was very direct video evidence, it would be impossible to prove.

There might even be no one who would believe that a mother would kill her own daughter.

Even if it was just accidentally pushing her off.

But long ago, Yang Jiani had already killed Qi Jiao's soul.

The diary Qi Jiao left behind could only serve as indirect evidence to prove that Yang Jiani had committed domestic violence. But Qi Jiao was dead, and the authenticity of that diary could not be verified.

Everything seemed to be covering for Yang Jiani's actions.

She was an adult, and Qi Jiao was a child.

So the violence an adult inflicted on a child could be disguised under the skin of familial love.

Thus the violence was rationalized.

This in itself was the most unreasonable thing.

The line between disciplining a child through hitting and scolding and domestic violence was too weak.

There were always people exploiting loopholes in the law, standing at the edge of morality.

"I won't come forward." Gu Xingyue directly stated her position. "If I come forward, I would betray the director. I can't possibly do that."

Liang Shi asked, "Does Yang Jiani have something on the director?"

Gu Xingyue paused for a moment, but ultimately chose not to hide it and honestly nodded.

"So you became Qi Jiao as an exchange, right?" Liang Shi asked again.

Gu Xingyue nodded again. Considering that she didn't have much time, she said directly, "I can't talk about the orphanage matters, but the director handed me over to Yang Jiani back then because of my illness. Yang Jiani could pay for my medical treatment, so the director gave me to her and had me become her daughter."

"If it weren't for my illness, even if Yang Jiani had something on the director, he wouldn't have handed me over to her." Gu Xingyue said, "As for Qi Jiao's matter, I've thought about it carefully. All the legitimate paths won't work. If you want to get justice for Qi Jiao, the only way is to kill, but you would be punished for it. It's not worth it."

At this moment, Gu Xingyue analyzed the current situation—calm and composed, her tone carrying indifference and disgust.

When speaking of the final outcome, there was only mockery.

But Liang Shi felt a sense of powerlessness listening to this.

The law exists to guarantee everyone's rights—life and death, crime and punishment.

Including bad people.

The unforgivably wicked, the perpetually evil, the crazed and inhumane.

They were all within the scope of legal protection.

The law was the most inhumane thing, yet it also had warmth.

But in this situation, it was a dead end with no solution.

After a brief moment of powerlessness, Liang Shi quickly adjusted her mindset and asked Gu Xingyue, "Then do you have any ideas?"

"I haven't figured it out yet." Gu Xingyue said, "I need some time."

Liang Shi looked at her. "Then be careful and stay safe. But you mentioned Chen Mian on the phone earlier—what does she have to do with this matter?"

"Do you remember the paper I gave you?" Gu Xingyue asked. "It was Qi Jiao's diary. It mentioned someone she once had a secret crush on—that person was Chen Mian."

Liang Shi was startled. "What? My sister really likes this artist. She and I used to be art studio classmates. She's a bit older than me."

"Yes." Gu Xingyue said, "She was in the same class as Qi Jiao. The night before last, I received a phone call from her."

Liang Shi quickly processed this information, then thought of the original owner's one interaction with Chen Mian in the art studio.

Calculating the time, it was right when Qi Jiao hadn't died yet.

At that time, Chen Mian had said two cryptic sentences, carrying a hint of contempt.

Chapter 111-3

"Her diary only mentioned two people—one was you, and one was Chen Mian." Gu Xingyue rapidly relayed the information. "She was seen walking together with Chen Mian by Yang Jiani. In fact, it was because it was raining that day, and Chen Mian held an umbrella to walk her to the school gate. The two of them were pushing the umbrella back and forth between each other, and their hands accidentally touched. Yang Jiani thought she was in a puppy love relationship, and then her hands were beaten swollen with a ruler."

"Yang Jiani's possessiveness had reached an appalling level. She didn't allow anyone else to get close to Qi Jiao, nor did she allow Qi Jiao to make friends. So Qi Jiao was often alone at school, and her interactions with Chen Mian weren't many. After reading her diary, I always thought it was her one-sided secret crush on Chen Mian. But the night before last, Chen Mian seemed to have been drunk."

After Gu Xingyue finished speaking, she played a recording for Liang Shi.

In her impression, Chen Mian's voice was very cold and clear, her tone somewhat arrogant and not very likeable, but she also didn't talk to people much.

Yet in this recording, Chen Mian's voice was quite soft. You could tell she had drunk too much. When calling Qi Jiao's name, her voice was gentle and lingering with affection.

She said, "Qi Jiao, I dreamed of you again. Are you doing okay? I miss you."

She also said, "Qi Jiao, don't jump... don't jump... I wasn't there below to catch you."

"Where did you go? To be honest, there was a period of time when I really hated you, because you disappeared for no reason. Later, I stopped hating you, because I found out that you died. How could you have died? Someone who was fine even after jumping off the rooftop—how could you die?"

"But how ridiculous. As soon as you died, your mother found a replacement. How could someone like that be worthy of being a mother?"

Chen Mian's voice gradually became drowsy. "Ah Jiao, if only I had the ability to hide you away."

The recording ended there. Liang Shi listened with mixed emotions.

If only there had really been someone who could have hidden Qi Jiao away back then.

But there were no "if onlys."

Gu Xingyue said, "If you know her, tell her not to call anymore. I'm afraid Yang Jiani will find out."

Her voice was very cold.

But Liang Shi heard a hint of determination in it. She looked at her and asked, "What are you planning to do?"

"Haven't figured it out yet." Gu Xingyue curved her lips into a smile. "But it should be something interesting."

That smile carried a hint of madness.

"I've hidden the original of Qi Jiao's diary." Gu Xingyue said, "What I gave you is all hand-copied by me. I didn't add or remove a single sentence. Also, pass this on to my brother."

The brother she referred to was Gu Zhaoyuan.

Gu Xingyue handed over a blue envelope. "He'll understand when he sees it."

Liang Shi put away the envelope. Seeing that something was off about her, she couldn't help but say, "Mr. Gu was very disappointed when he didn't get to see you last time. He misses you very much. And Director Gu—because he sent you away and saw Yang Jiani abuse you, he feels very guilty. Angel Orphanage has now been converted into Ci'ai Nursing Home¹. Director Gu's mental state isn't very good right now, and his health is also deteriorating. So if you have time and are able to, I can take you there to see him."

"No need." Gu Xingyue pressed her lips together. "The director would definitely be even more upset if he saw me. When the time comes, if possible, I just want to see my brother."

Liang Shi acknowledged with a sound and said she was willing to help.

They had pretty much said everything that needed to be said. Liang Shi also thought of Cheng Ran, hesitating whether to tell Gu Xingyue about Cheng Ran's scummy words.

While she was hesitating, Gu Xingyue picked up the teapot beside her to add more tea. As she raised her hand, Liang Shi saw the blood marks on her wrist.

Liang Shi immediately grabbed her wrist and pulled up her sleeve.

On her wrist was a bloody mark that had already scabbed over. It was a shocking sight.

But from this mark, you could also tell how deep she had cut before.

"Why?" Liang Shi asked coldly.

"Otherwise, why do you think I have any freedom?" Gu Xingyue smiled and pulled her sleeve back down, covering that mark. "One always has to fight for something for oneself."

Looking at Gu Xingyue's cold and detached eyes, Liang Shi felt as if she was only now truly getting to know her.

A few seconds later, Liang Shi spoke the words that Cheng Ran had asked her to pass on. "Cheng Ran said that she also had thirty percent sincerity toward you."

Upon hearing this, Gu Xingyue was stunned. After a long while, she laughed.

On that seemingly docile face was a disdainful smile. "Who cares."

1. "Ci'ai" (慈愛) means "loving kindness" or "benevolent love" in Chinese, a fitting name for a nursing home. ⇐